

Illustration by SIDDHANT JUMDE

GLASSHOUSE

ARISE, SAINT CHANDY

At a memorial meeting for former Kerala chief minister Oommen Chandy, leader of the Opposition V.D. Satheesan demanded that the church declare the late Congress leader a saint as his tomb in Puthuppally had been attracting large crowds since his interment on July 21. Now, the Syrian Orthodox Church needs 'three miracle testimonies proving divine intervention' to initiate the sainthood process. Social media is already abuzz with memes of Chandy's powers—a poor widow visiting Chandy's tomb wins a Rs 80 lakh lottery while others are cured of chronic ills. Critics recall the insinuations Chandy endured in the 2013 'solar panel' controversy and joke that the party is looking for redemption in the 2024 election from an ex-CM who was "crucified by his own partymen" when he was alive.

Walkathon, Part II



With **Rahul Gandhi** reinstated as MP, some Congressmen are pushing for another round of the Bharat Jodo Yatra, this time from west to east. The proposal is to start it from the Sabarmati Ashram in Gujarat on Gandhi Jayanti (October 2). Also, there will be no permanent yatris this time except Rahul, so that the cavalcade is much smaller. Buoyed by the huge outpouring of support last time, the leaders expect thousands to join the yatra on their own every day. The Gandhi scion and his team haven't consented to the idea yet, as they feel it will disturb the momentum built for the assembly poll campaigns in four big states—Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh, Chhattisgarh and Telangana.

HANDS OF TIME



It was June 1976, India was seething under the Emergency, and a 25-year-old **Nitish Kumar** was on the run. The police did not have a photo of the young Turk who was part of Jayaprakash Narayan's Total Revolution movement, yet they identified him from among a group of activists; an informer had tipped them off about Nitish's habit of wearing his watch dial on the inside of his wrist. The intriguing episode was revealed in a book on the Bihar CM released in July. Incidentally, Nitish still wears his watch the same way, one of the few leaders who does so. Prime Minister Narendra Modi is another.

No Second Act

If there was any speculation that actor **Sunny Deol**, the BJP MP from Gurdaspur, Punjab, will recontest in 2024, it has vanished now. Recently, he was in Amritsar, an hour's drive from Gurdaspur, to promote his new film, *Gadar 2*, but chose not to visit his constituency where he was apparently last seen three years ago. Deol also skipped the monsoon session of Parliament where his attendance registers at an abysmal 19 per cent. In a strange turn of events, ex-Congressman Sunil Jakhar, whom Deol defeated in 2019, now heads the BJP's Punjab unit.



MILIND SHELTE

INJURY POLITICS



ANI

The BJP is making Rajasthan chief minister **Ashok Gehlot's** toe injuries a political issue. The CM injured the big toes on both feet in a June 30 accident, but the opposition says he is faking it to get voter sympathy in the upcoming assembly poll. Since Gehlot still has the bandages on, they are demanding that a panel of five doctors examine him and present a public report. Rubbing salt into the wounds, BJP leaders drew comparisons with West Bengal CM Mamata Banerjee, who was injured just before the 2021 assembly polls there and "played it up to garner sympathy votes". A visibly upset Gehlot says he can send his CT scan reports to anyone who needs hard evidence.

–by Kaushik Deka with Jeemon Jacob, Amitabh Srivastava, Rohit Parihar and Anilesh S. Mahajan